

The old hardware could not keep up with this upgrade, and the PCs soon took on 486 processors and 16 MB of RAM. Novell 3.11 ran the LAN.

Soon, the first Pentium came along. The first machine Uttamchandani got had two hard disks—one was a mirror disk for backups. The operating system changed from MS-DOS to Windows NT, but the software remained the same. A Paragon 36 dot matrix filled in for the printing tasks.

The 1996 upgrade had taken care of the requirements of multiple-drawer cash transactions and banking transactions. In 1999, Uttamchandani started off with an Oracle database application. By the middle of the year, he opted for Microsoft's SQL Server. Delphi was used for the front-end. The entire application development took two years, and was completed in December of 2001.

The State Of The Art

At the current level of evolution, the key benefits of Uttamchandani's system include:

'Multiple cash drawer monitoring: transactions from all three drawers are accounted for in real-time, and cash-in-hand is a password-protected option.

'Rack filling report: location-wise reports generated for each of the 145 racks, which means time savings since the rack refiller has a list of not only



Tech support at the Welcome Store

items required, but also the exact shelf in the warehouse from which it has to be picked up.

'Real-time inventory assessment: three boxes at the bottom of the sales screen displays the current stock of the item, and the location of the item in the warehouse and the shop.

'Re-order report generation.

'Expense register: all petty cash dealings are maintained here.

'Mirroring of bank account.

'Multiple sales screens: "simultaneous" billing of two or more customers because of the "minimise" option: one customer's bill process can be minimised and put on hold while the next one is being processed.

'A database of top customers and profits generated from each.

'Charting of sales and profits for analysing sales trends and forecasting.

'User privileges can be defined and password protection assigned for different registers such as purchase, expense and cash drawer reports.

On To Telecommuting

Tech-savvy though he was, it was only in early

Tech Armour at Welcome Store

- Three desktop computers with P4 processors
- Two 9-inch colour monitor and one 15-inch LCD monitor
- One laptop
- Two Epson Printers
- A GSM Modem
- A 100 Mbps LAN switch
- A CAT-5 cable
- Total cost: Rs 1,40,000

2006 that Uttamchandani got himself a mobile phone. His reason: any technology should help in saving time or money, otherwise it is pointless. With the help of a GSM modem, a SIM card, and Real Time—a software he got free because of his offer to run it on a trial basis—Uttamchandani can now access all sales and purchase reports on his cell phone.

Opting for a "200 SMS free" plan, he decided, was the best bet. The most important information is the outstandings due and payable, categorised customer or supplier-wise. Apart from that, total sales, profits categorised date/month or yearly, and the latest purchase price of any item with its date of purchase and supplier is available on an SMS, thus giving him much-needed mobility while being in command and control of a business which, by its very definition, demands physical presence.

Tech Not For Tech's Sake

Uttamchandani used this freedom to overcome the limitations of a counter-sale/cash business which, in the Indian context, requires the presence of the proprietor who could only be relieved by a family member, thus requiring at least two persons from the family to be fully occupied. While technology has freed Uttamchandani's son to concentrate on his career with an MNC, it has granted Uttamchandani the leeway to undertake other ventures—such as manufacturing of a petroleum jelly, and also the time to pursue his hobby of interior designing.

Another advantage of systematic data processing was capitalising on the market research requirements of large corporations. For example, a multinational company wanted to buy three years' sales data in nine categories of soaps, which he could give them at the stroke of a key. He made a similar deal with a market-research organisation in town. His tech initiatives have now generated another revenue source for him.

Also very popular is Welcome Store's customer loyalty program. Customers are tracked on the basis of their annual and monthly billing, and profitability rankings are developed for the top customers. Annual prizes are given away depending on a customer's rank.

Welcome Store is a classic example of the possibility of technology deployment even for a small setup. Tech is certainly a business productivity enabler even for such stores. Systematic inventory management in this little retail outlet not only proved to be a valuable tool in hedging against typical business risks, but also opened up vistas in data mining and business expansion. ■

philip_malayil@thinkdigit.com